

MUMBAI INDIA

Chaat on a Mumbai Beach

Mumbai is India's economic powerhouse and the cosmopolitan home of Bollywood, the world's most prolific film industry. The city also epitomizes the subcontinent's diversity: it has the worst slums in Asia as well as some of the world's priciest apartments. Frenetically fast-paced, many of its 17 million inhabitants eat on the go – and traditional *chaat* is the snack of choice.



The head-spinning modern city of Mumbai was originally seven islands populated exclusively by fishermen. The islands belonged to several different dynasties over the centuries, but fell under European control when the Portuguese invaded in 1508, renaming the islands *Bom Bahia* (the Good Bay). Some 150 years later, the Portuguese handed the islands to the British, who headquartered the East India Company in "Bombay." They reclaimed vast swaths of land to join the islands together and began a rapid expansion of the port. By the time India gained independence in 1947, Bombay was by far its most prosperous city, boasting a fine collection of Raj-era architecture, including the triumphal arch of the Gateway of India, the Taj Hotel, the VT train station, and the Prince of Wales Museum.

The city's reputation as a financial and trade center was augmented by the booming entertainment business, and Mumbai, as it was renamed in 1996, was soon displaying the brash confidence and wealth of the growing middle class. The constant stream of

immigrants from other states and foreign lands added to the cosmopolitan atmosphere and to Mumbai's cuisine – so it is fitting that the most popular dish here is not a single item but a collection of snacks that fall under the blanket term *chaat*. They are available at thousands of stands and roadside *dhabas* (very basic restaurants) throughout the urban sprawl, but the most concentrated and famous string of *chaat* stands line the back of Chowpatty Beach at the end of Marine Drive.

If there is one common ingredient, it is crispy fried dough known as *puri*, which is mixed with a variety of ingredients to produce the different types of *chaat*. It is usually served on a tin plate or in a banana-leaf bowl and, of course, eaten with the right hand. Mumbai's favorite version is *bhel puri*, a mixture of *puri*, deep-fried vermicelli, puffed rice, potato, hot pepper paste, chopped onions, cilantro, and tamarind sauce. A popular variation, *pani puri*, includes a lentil and potato stuffing with sweet chutney. *Pav bhaji*, found virtually everywhere, is a Portuguese-style bun filled with a spicy vegetable stew. Hot, spicy, and nourishing, this is food for fueling enterprise.

Ganesh Chaturthi

Not actually a food festival in its own right, Mumbai's renowned Ganesh Chaturthi is an excellent occasion to sample the delights of *chaat* at Chowpatty Beach. It is a birthday party for the beloved elephant-headed deity Ganesh, and one of the most important and popular Hindu festivals. It falls some time between late August and late September and lasts for up to ten days, culminating in thousands of images of the chubby god being immersed in the soupy waters of the Arabian Sea. Given that the monsoon is often still in full swing during the event, visitors are just as likely to get completely soaked as participants, even if they do not assist in the deity-dunking. Ganesh is said to be fond of sweet desserts, so the *chaat-wallahs* come out in full force, making sure there are plenty of sweet and savory snacks available for his birthday.



Above Mumbai's street stands are renowned for their great *chaat*, especially *bhel puri*



The Best Places to Eat Chaat

Chowpatty Beach Stands

inexpensive

The whole concept of Indian *chaat* is that it's sold by outlets that are as transient as their customers. Consequently, it is hard to pin down a specific stand amid the throng of *chaat-wallahs* who wheel their carts up and down the back of Chowpatty Beach, advertising their goods with piercing cries or clanging bells. What is indisputable is that locals in Mumbai will all tell you that this is the place to come.

So, let your senses lead you to the most appealing plate of *bhel puri* to suit your own palate. Rest assured that while the stand itself might be dented and grubby, the food will be freshly prepared and the high turnover ensures it remains so.

Chowpatty beach, Mumbai; open all day until late evening

Also in Mumbai

Chaat is available at every turn in Mumbai, but here are two well-known spots. Near the GPO (the main post office), in bustling Crawford Market's 3rd Lane, **Eden's Snacks (inexpensive)** is one of central Mumbai's most popular places for grabbing a quick plate of *bhel puri* or *sev puri* (with crispy *papri* wafers) while shopping. On Wodehouse Road in Colaba, where most foreigners stay, **Sunshine Snack Corner (+91 22 2215 0646; inexpensive)** is worth trying. If you would rather pass on such unadulterated street food, try **Chaat Lo (inexpensive)**, behind Chowpatty Beach opposite Bhavan's College, which makes many types of *chaat* as well as samosas and *chola bhature*, a Punjabi dish involving spicy chickpeas and fried *puri* bread.

Also in India

Different types of *chaat* are widespread throughout the country. In the capital, Delhi, **Chaat Corner (inexpensive)** on Arya Samaj Road offers a great range. In Chennai, in the south, you can find local versions of street foods at **Chit Chat (inexpensive)** on the city's main thoroughfare, Anna Salai.

Around the World

Apart from well-known snacks like samosas and pakora, Mumbai-style *chaat* can be hard to come by outside India, as most restaurants serve more conventional meals. However, London has quite a few options, such as **Santok Maa's Bhel Poori House (+44 20 8665 0626; inexpensive)** in Thornton Heath, which specializes in *bhel puri*, as the name suggests. In Canada, Toronto's **Bombay Bhel (www.bombaybhelrestaurant.com; moderate)** offers *pani*, *bhel*, *sev*, and chickpea-filled *dahi puri* among its appetizers.